RDG-P6 · PRÁCTICA 04

Gapped text

Hoja 04 · Memorias · dificultad 4 de 4

7 huecos (37–43) · 8 párrafos (A–H), uno sobrante · 2 puntos por hueco · tiempo orientativo: 18 minutos · sin consultar la teoría

You are going to read an extract from a memoir. Seven paragraphs have been removed from the extract. Choose from the paragraphs **A–H** the one which fits each gap (37–43). There is one extra paragraph which you do not need to use. Mark your answers on the answer sheet.

The second name on the page

A writer remembers his mother, who translated Italian crime novels at the kitchen table.

My mother's dictionaries came to me last winter, in two cardboard boxes that still smelt faintly of her kitchen. There are eleven of them, most of them Italian–English, and their spines are broken at the places she must have needed most. I had meant to give them to a charity shop. Instead they are on the shelf above my desk, where I find, somewhat to my irritation, that I consult them more often than I would care to admit.

37 _____

I knew that the books were Italian, and that she was making them English, but I was a literal-minded child and drew what seemed to me the obvious conclusion. When my class was asked to describe our parents' jobs, I announced that my mother wrote murder stories. It was the high point of my social career at primary school, and it lasted until Mrs Pryce, who had read one, took me gently aside.

38 _____

That, more or less, was how I went on seeing it for the next ten years, and as I grew older my view of the evenings at the kitchen table hardened from disappointment into something closer to impatience. She would read sentences aloud to the empty room, try them three different ways and ask me, if I was unlucky enough to be passing, whether a man could be said to 'saunter' into a police station. I usually told her I had no idea.

39 _____

It was years before I understood what I had said. I was at university by then, reading, of all things, modern languages, and in my second year I was set a passage of Italian prose to translate for a seminar. It was three paragraphs long. I spent a week on it, and when the tutor returned it, the margins were full of pencilled questions, most of them variations on the one my mother used to ask: is that really what he would say?

40 _____

That was as close as we came to an apology, on either side, and it was enough. From then on I read her translations as they appeared, and I began to notice what I had never troubled to look for: the decisions. A detective in one of the early novels says of a suspect something that means, roughly, 'that one knows more than he lets on'. In my mother's version he remarks that the man is 'not nearly as stupid as he looks', which is better, and funnier, and not in the original at all.

41 _____

It was a suspicion she kept to the end. She retired at seventy, after forty-one books, and gave away the typewriter but not the dictionaries. In her last years, when her eyesight had begun to fail, she would ask me to read her own

translations aloud to her, and she would listen with her eyes closed, now and then raising a hand to stop me at a phrase she wanted to hear again. Occasionally she would wince, and say that she could have done better.

42 _____

It was with that sentence that I began, this winter, to read the originals alongside her versions, her dictionaries open beside me. My Italian is not what it was, and I am slow. But I find that I can often tell, before I have checked, where she has taken a liberty, because it is at exactly those points that the English begins to sound like her.

43 _____

Her handwriting survives too, in pencil, in the margins of the dictionaries: a tick here, a question mark there, now and then a word of her own where the dictionary had failed her. I have twice resolved to keep only the best of the eleven, and twice failed. Each time I take one down to decide, it falls open at a page she used, and I find myself reading the entry she must have read, and wondering what she was looking for, and whether she found it.

A At fifteen I went further. During an argument whose cause I have long since forgotten, I told her that what she did was not real writing, that anyone with a dictionary could do it, and that she should stop pretending otherwise. She did not answer. She went back to her typing, a little more slowly than before, and neither of us mentioned it again.

B It is an odd way to hear someone's voice: through a stranger's plot, in the mouth of a detective who never existed, under another writer's name. Yet there it is, page after page, as unmistakable as her handwriting, and a good deal more patient.

C For most of my childhood they lived on the kitchen table. Every evening, once the plates had been cleared, my mother would set them out in a row beside a paperback with a lurid cover and a typewriter with a temperamental letter e, and work until long after I had been sent to bed. I fell asleep for years to the sound of it.

D Whether this was translation or something else is a question I have since heard argued at conferences, generally by people who have never had to make a joke work in two languages. My mother would have found the debate faintly absurd. She thought of herself as an artisan rather than an artist, and she was suspicious of anyone who used the word 'creative' about her work.

E When I finally apologised, years later, she waved it away. She had said far worse things to her own mother, she told me, and in any case I had been right: anyone with a dictionary could do it. The difficulty was doing it well, and that, she said, was a different matter entirely, and not one she expected a fifteen-year-old to understand.

F I telephoned her that evening, ostensibly to ask about a word. We talked about the passage for an hour. She did not mention the argument, and nor did I, but at the end she remarked that I probably now understood why the letter e on her typewriter had never worked properly, and I could hear that she was smiling.

G Once, she laughed out loud. It was at the sentence about the man who was not nearly as stupid as he looked, and when I asked her what was funny she said only that she had been rather pleased with it at the time and was glad to find that she still was. It was, I think, the only compliment I ever heard her pay herself.

H There was, she explained, another name on the cover, and it was not my mother's. Hers was inside, on the title page, in type so small that I had to hold the book up to the window to read it. I remember the disappointment exactly. I had been the son of a novelist, and now I was the son of a kind of copying machine.

Hoja de respuestas

Marca una sola letra por hueco; cada letra se usa una vez como máximo. Al corregir, 2 puntos por acierto; los errores no restan. Anota también el tiempo empleado: el objetivo en el examen son unos 18 minutos.

Nº	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	Puntos
37	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	/ 2
38	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	/ 2
39	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	/ 2
40	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	/ 2
41	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	/ 2
42	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	/ 2
43	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	/ 2
							Total		**/ 14**

Párrafo sobrante: _____ (no puntúa; sirve para comprobar). Tiempo empleado: _____ minutos.

SOLUCIONES

2 puntos por acierto. Cada solución explica qué une el párrafo con lo de antes (←) y con lo de después (→), con citas de los dos lados; cuando hay un párrafo tentador, por qué falla; y, al final, por qué el sobrante no entra en ningún hueco. Los números de sección remiten a RDG-P6_Teoria_v1.

Clave rápida

Nº	Clave	Empieza	Teoría
37	**C**	For most of my childhood they lived…	§3.1 · §4.1
38	**H**	There was, she explained, another name on…	§4.5 · §4.1
39	**A**	At fifteen I went further.	§4.1 · §3.1
40	**F**	I telephoned her that evening, ostensibly to…	§4.1 · §5.2
41	**D**	Whether this was translation or something else…	§4.1 · §4.4
42	**G**	Once, she laughed out loud.	§4.3 · §4.1
43	**B**	It is an odd way to hear…	§4.4 · §4.1
—	**E**	When I finally apologised, years later, she… *(sobrante)*	§5.1 · §3.1

Explicación por hueco

37 • C • *For most of my childhood they lived on the…*

← Con lo anterior. El primer párrafo está en el presente: los diccionarios están ahora en el estante del narrador, que los consulta more often than I would care to admit. C retrocede a la infancia con una marca temporal y un pronombre: For most of my childhood they lived on the kitchen table. El pronombre they solo puede ser los diccionarios (§3.1).

→ Con lo siguiente. C presenta el trabajo de la madre (a paperback with a lurid cover) sin decir todavía en qué consistía. El párrafo siguiente lo presupone con artículo definido y lo explica: I knew that the books were Italian, and that she was making them English.

Tentador: B. It is an odd way to hear someone's voice podría comentar el apego del narrador a los diccionarios, pero B habla de oír la voz de la madre en sus traducciones, que todavía no han aparecido, y el párrafo siguiente necesita un antecedente para the books.

Teoría: §3.1 Hilo narrativo · §4.1 Pistas hacia atrás

38 • H • *There was, she explained, another name on the cover…*

← Con lo anterior. El párrafo anterior termina cuando una maestra se lleva aparte al narrador: until Mrs Pryce, who had read one, took me gently aside. H reproduce lo que ella le dijo, en estilo indirecto: There was, she explained, another name on the cover. El pronombre she es Mrs Pryce, no la madre (§4.5, voz).

→ Con lo siguiente. H termina con la decepción del niño: now I was the son of a kind of copying machine. El párrafo siguiente la recoge con un demostrativo y la prolonga diez años: That, more or less, was how I went on seeing it for the next ten years.

Teoría: §4.5 Tiempo verbal y voz · §4.1 Pistas hacia atrás

39 · A · *At fifteen I went further.*

← Con lo anterior. El párrafo anterior describe la impaciencia del adolescente (I usually told her I had no idea). A la lleva más lejos con un comparativo y una edad: At fifteen I went further. La palabra further presupone una actitud anterior del mismo tipo (§4.1).

→ Con lo siguiente. A cuenta la discusión y el silencio que la siguió: neither of us mentioned it again. El párrafo siguiente la recoge y salta en el tiempo: It was years before I understood what I had said. La expresión what I had said remite a las palabras del adolescente, que solo están en A.

Tentador: E. When I finally apologised, years later parece seguir a la impaciencia del adolescente, pero en este punto no se ha contado ninguna ofensa de la que disculparse. Además, una disculpa years later no puede ir antes de It was years before I understood what I had said.

Teoría: §4.1 Pistas hacia atrás · §3.1 Hilo narrativo

40 · F · *I telephoned her that evening, ostensibly to ask about…*

← Con lo anterior. El párrafo anterior termina con la pregunta del tutor, la misma que hacía la madre: is that really what he would say? F cuenta la reacción del narrador ese mismo día: I telephoned her that evening, ostensibly to ask about a word. El adverbio ostensibly deja ver el verdadero motivo sin nombrarlo.

→ Con lo siguiente. F termina con una reconciliación sin palabras: She did not mention the argument, and nor did I, pero ella sonríe. El párrafo siguiente la valora con understatement: That was as close as we came to an apology, on either side, and it was enough.

Tentador: E. Encaja muy bien por detrás: después de entender lo que había dicho, lo natural es disculparse (When I finally apologised, years later, she waved it away). Pero choca con el párrafo siguiente: si hubo una disculpa explícita, That was as close as we came to an apology sería falso (§5.1, contradicción).

Teoría: §4.1 Pistas hacia atrás · §5.2 Trampas de encaje

41 · D · *Whether this was translation or something else is a…*

← Con lo anterior. El párrafo anterior termina con una libertad de la madre, una frase better, and funnier, and not in the original at all. D la convierte en objeto de debate con un demostrativo: Whether this was translation or something else. El demostrativo this es esa libertad, no la traducción en general.

→ Con lo siguiente. D termina con la desconfianza de la madre hacia la palabra creative: she was suspicious of anyone who used the word ‘creative’ about her work. El párrafo siguiente la convierte en sustantivo: It was a suspicion she kept to the end (§4.4).

Tentador: B. It is an odd way to hear someone’s voice podría comentar la frase que la madre inventó, pero el párrafo siguiente empieza con It was a suspicion she kept to the end, y en B no hay ninguna sospecha.

Teoría: §4.1 Pistas hacia atrás · §4.4 Cadenas léxicas

42 · G · *Once, she laughed out loud.*

← Con lo anterior. El párrafo anterior describe la reacción habitual de la madre al oír sus traducciones: Occasionally she would wince. G cuenta la excepción: Once, she laughed out loud. El contraste no lleva conector: lo marcan Once frente a Occasionally, y la risa frente al gesto de disgusto (§4.3).

→ Con lo siguiente. G vuelve a una frase concreta, the sentence about the man who was not nearly as stupid as he looked. El párrafo siguiente empieza por ella con un demostrativo: It was with that sentence that I began. Aunque la frase ya había aparecido antes, that sentence necesita una mención inmediata, y solo G la ofrece.

Tentador: E. Una disculpa en la vejez de la madre parece posible tras say that she could have done better, pero el texto ya ha dicho That was as close as we came to an apology, on either side, y una disculpa explícita posterior lo contradice. Además, that sentence se quedaría sin antecedente cercano.

Teoría: §4.3 Conectores y adverbios de frase · §4.1 Pistas hacia atrás

43 · B · *It is an odd way to hear someone's voice…*

← Con lo anterior. El párrafo anterior termina con la idea central del pasaje: en las libertades de la traductora, the English begins to sound like her. B lo comenta: It is an odd way to hear someone's voice. La palabra voice recoge sound like her con otras palabras (§4.4).

→ Con lo siguiente. B termina comparando esa voz con la letra de la madre: as unmistakable as her handwriting. El último párrafo retoma la palabra con un aditivo: Her handwriting survives too. El adverbio too presupone otra cosa que sobrevive: la voz de la que habla B.

Tentador: D. Encaja por detrás: Whether this was translation or something else podría referirse a las libertades que el narrador descubre ahora. Pero falla por delante, porque el último párrafo necesita Her handwriting, que D no menciona; y D es el único párrafo que prepara It was a suspicion she kept to the end.

Teoría: §4.4 Cadenas léxicas · §4.1 Pistas hacia atrás

El párrafo sobrante

E · *When I finally apologised, years later, she waved it…*

- **Huecos 37 y 38.** La disculpa presupone una ofensa que todavía no se ha contado: las palabras que E repite (anyone with a dictionary could do it) son las de la discusión de los quince años, y en estos huecos el narrador aún es un niño.
- **Hueco 39.** When I finally apologised, years later iría antes de la ofensa y antes de It was years before I understood what I had said: la disculpa no puede preceder al momento en que el narrador entiende lo que dijo.
- **Hueco 40.** Encaje por un solo lado. Por detrás funciona, pero el párrafo siguiente dice That was as close as we came to an apology, on either side, y E cuenta una disculpa explícita.
- **Huecos 41–43.** Una vez dicho That was as close as we came to an apology, una disculpa posterior contradice al narrador en cualquier punto del texto. Además, lo que sigue a cada hueco presupone algo que E no contiene: It was a suspicion she kept to the end, that sentence, Her handwriting survives too.

Teoría: §5.1 Cómo se fabrica el sobrante · §3.1 Hilo narrativo